



Inspiring Excellence

HUM 102: INTRODUCTION TO PHILOSOPHY

SUMMER 2025

SECOND TAKE-HOME ESSAY

John Locke (1632- 1704) was one of the most influential British philosophers of the seventeenth century. He was an empiricist and often called the “Father of Liberalism”. Locke is remembered most for his political philosophy. His writings have had a profound influence not only on philosophy but also on political thought, shaping ideas about democracy, human rights, and the nature of knowledge. Locke’s claims marked a significant turn in modern philosophy, objecting the rationalist view of thinkers such as René Descartes, who believed that certain ideas are innate, ideas built or written into the mind from birth. Locke rejected this claim and offered an alternative view. He argued that the mind begins as a blank slate and that all knowledge is acquired through experience.

In *‘An Essay Concerning Human Understanding’*, Locke directly challenges the rationalist claim that humans are born with innate ideas. Descartes had argued that certain truths such as the concept of God, mathematical truths, or basic moral principles must be innate because they are universal and cannot be explained through experience alone (Descartes, 1985). If every culture and individual seems to recognize them, Descartes reasoned, they must have been written in the human mind by nature itself.

Locke rejects this claim for several reasons. First, he argues that such ideas are not universal as they are not present in the minds of children or mentally deficient people (Locke, 1999, Book I, Ch. 2). Because if there were innate ideas everyone would agree with each other about everything. Everyone would immediately be aware of them and there should not be any disagreement. Yet, disagreement exists. Not all cultures or individuals share the same beliefs about God, morality, or mathematics. For example, while some believe in one God, others

believe in many, and still there are people that deny the existence of gods altogether. If the idea of God were truly innate, such disagreements would not exist.

Second, Locke insists that if innate ideas existed, they would be present in one's mind by birth. So, even a child or infant would be aware and have access to those ideas. Then they should come out already knowing geometry, physics or logic, but they clearly do not. Hence, Locke's main claim is that all ideas come from experience. People do not have access to these supposedly innate ideas until they learn them from experiences of the past. For example, a toddler only knows the difference between 'hot' and 'cold' by touching a warm mug or a cold piece of ice. This knowledge is not inborn but gained from experience. A toddler touching a hot mug learns that 'hot' is painful through sensation, not because they were born with this knowledge. If such truths were innate, even a young child should know which mug is hot instinctively.

For this reason, Locke adopts what he calls a "historical, plain method" (Locke, 1999, Introduction, §2). Rather than assuming that knowledge must come from innate reason, he directs attention to what is obvious, to everyday experience. This empirical method resembles how scientists like Galileo and Newton worked, who built knowledge step by step from gathering observations, identifying patterns, and drawing conclusions from experience. For Locke, ideas are not implanted in the mind from birth but are acquired through sensation and reflection.

To replace the theory of innate ideas, Locke introduces his famous metaphor of the *tabula rasa*, or "blank slate" (Locke, 1999, Book II, Ch. 1). According to this view, at birth, the mind

contains no ideas at all. Instead, it is blank like a white paper, on which the ideas of the world are written down through experience. This view reshapes how we think about human learning and development. For Locke, all knowledge and ideas originates from the gradual accumulation of experiences.

The idea of the '*tabula rasa*' can be easily demonstrated in ordinary life. Consider a baby encountering a bright pink flower for the first time. The soft petals, the vivid color, and the sweet fragrance all make an impression. None of these are innate, they enter the mind, through experience and are stored for later comparison. Over time, the child may learn to connect similar experiences, such as recognizing other flowers and eventually form the broader idea of plants.. In this way, the 'blank slate' gradually fills up with content.

Locke's metaphor has broader implications. It shows human development depends on education and environment because the mind is shaped entirely by experience and how we expose ourselves to the world greatly influences who we become.

After rejecting innate ideas and establishing the *tabula rasa*, Locke explains how ideas enter the mind. According to him, all simple ideas come from one of the two sources: sensation and reflection (Locke, 1999, Book II, Ch. 1–2).

1. Sensation refers to the idea or impressions we receive from external objects through our senses, which includes sight, smell, touch etc. For example, when I see a cup of coffee, feel its warm surface, smell its rich aroma, and taste its bitterness, all of these impressions are delivered through sensation. These sensory experiences give rise to ideas of color,

taste, texture and other qualities.

2. Reflection refers to ideas of the mind's internal operations, such as thinking, doubting, or believing. Unlike sensation, it is not directly tied to external objects but to our awareness of mental processes. Reflection is the mind's ability to self-reflect on its own activities. For instance, when I notice myself recalling yesterday's events or when I am aware that I am making a choice, I am engaging in reflection.

Locke emphasizes that both sources are essential. Without sensation, we would have no external data and without reflection, we would not be aware of the operations of our own minds.

Moreover, Locke distinguishes between simple ideas and complex ideas as a way of explaining how knowledge develops (Locke, 1999, Book II, Ch. 12).

- Simple ideas are the most basic elements of thought. They arrive directly from experiences through sensation or reflection and are received passively by the mind. It cannot be broken down further. For example, the sound of laughter, the feeling of warmth or the experience of pain, are all simple ideas. They arrive in the mind directly, without our control, we cannot analyze them into smaller parts.
- Complex ideas, on the other hand, are constructed by the mind out of simple ideas. The mind has the active power to combine, compare, and abstract these simple ideas to create more sophisticated concepts. For instance, the idea of a 'book' combines the simple ideas of rectangular shape, the texture of paper, the sound of pages turning, and the sight of printed words. Similarly, abstract concepts such as justice or friendship are formed by

combining and reflecting on multiple experiences.

An everyday example for the distinction would be imagining a child learning what a dog is. At first, the child experiences simple ideas: the barking sound, the feel of fur, the sight of a wagging tail. Over time, the child combines these simple ideas into the complex idea of a dog. Later, the child might form even more complex ideas, such as pets or animals, grouping several complex ideas together. Locke's explanation helps us see how the human mind can move from basic sensory impressions to sophisticated concepts without needing innate ideas.

Finally, Locke addresses the question of how we know physical objects. To do this, he introduces the distinction between primary and secondary qualities (Locke, 1999, Book II, Ch. 8).

- Primary qualities are qualities that exist in the object itself. These are the qualities that can be quantified through scientific observation and calculations. Physical qualities exist independently of our perception and are really out there. These include shape, size, speed, and mass. A cube, for instance, will remain six-sided whether or not someone looks at it.
- Secondary qualities are qualities that do not exist in the object as they appear to us but arise from the interaction between the object and our senses. Locke says that these are the properties that are produced in the mind like, color, taste, sound, and smell. The objects out there have a tendency to produce this experience in us. For example, the sweetness of sugar is not a property of sugar in itself but the effect it has on our taste buds.

This distinction shows Locke's careful attention to how perception works. When I pick up a coffee mug, its round shape and weight (primary qualities) are in the mug itself. But the taste of the coffee and the smell (secondary qualities) depends on the interaction of the mug's contents with my senses. This suggests that while our senses give us access to the world, they do not always give us the world as it is and sometimes present qualities that depend on our perspective.

Locke's philosophy of knowledge represents a profound shift toward empiricism. Locke's contribution to philosophy is not just theoretical but practical. By placing experience at the center of knowledge, he emphasizes the importance of learning, education, and observation. His philosophy continues to shape how we think about knowledge, science, and human understanding.

References

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Descartes, R. (1985). *Meditations on First Philosophy*. In J. Cottingham, R. Stoothoff, & D. Murdoch (Eds.), *The Philosophical Writings of Descartes* (Vol. 2). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.